

Opinion | In a changed world, Canada faces an information war. There is an answer

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Canada faces a war on two fronts: an economic campaign to weaken and ultimately annex us, and an information war to manipulate public opinion and destabilize our democracy. Incredibly, the United States is now, alongside authoritarian regimes such as Russia and China, using economic pressure, territorial aggression and digital propaganda to divide Canadians, distort elections and sow mistrust in institutions.

Yet Canada has struggled to mount an adequate defence. Recent legislative efforts intended to protect our digital domain have stalled. When Parliament was prorogued, two critical bills — concerning elections security and online harms — failed to pass. These overdue bills were designed to strengthen protections against foreign interference, limit harmful online content and hold digital platforms accountable. Their absence leaves Canada vulnerable at precisely the moment it needs new tools to fight back.

This is why Canada urgently needs to re-establish a critical portfolio for the digital age and appoint a federal minister of communications. For too long, our government has lacked a dedicated advocate to safeguard the integrity of our information system — the communications tools and services on which Canadians rely.

From 1969 to 1996, Canada had a minister of communications who oversaw radio, television and telecommunications, ensuring our airwaves weren't dominated by foreign interests. Under cultural champions such as Pierre Juneau, Canada boldly regulated media content, creating space for Canadian stories and voices. The famous “CanCon” rules that Juneau pioneered secured airtime for domestic artists, launching a golden era of Canadian music and television. This proactive approach wasn't accidental — it required vision, political will and strong leadership. Juneau's legacy demonstrates that assertive communications policy is vital to our sovereignty.

Of course, Canada has used robust regulations to protect not only its culture but also its economy. In 2008, prudent financial oversight shielded us from the global banking crisis that devastated institutions in the U.S. and Europe. Canada's careful, forward-looking approach proved to be our saving grace. Its basis was simple: prudence and

accountability to Canadians. Now we must apply to our information system the same principles that have successfully protected our financial system.

Make no mistake: Canada's information system — the digital infrastructure that Canadians rely on daily for news, civic participation and emergency communications — is as vital to national stability as our financial system is. And just as strong banking regulations guard against economic catastrophe, comprehensive oversight of our digital landscape is essential to protecting democracy, public safety and national security. Without clear accountability, this system becomes vulnerable to exploitation by malign actors intent on undermining our society.

The task is urgent. Elon Musk's ownership of X has resulted in mass layoffs of the company's safety teams and significantly relaxed moderation policies. This has led to a surge in misinformation (including from its owner), as well as hate speech. Similarly, Meta recently announced that it would scrap third-party fact-checkers, remove its trust and safety team and scale down content moderation, undercutting vital safeguards against misinformation. The timing couldn't be worse: with an election coming and two-thirds of Canadians reliant on these platforms for their news, Canada's information system is dangerously vulnerable to manipulation.

A new communications minister, empowered to act decisively, could introduce comprehensive legislation — a Tech Accountability and Sovereignty Act — mandating platform transparency, limitations on data collection and targeted advertising, safety standards for children and swift responses to harmful disinformation, including foreign interference. Platforms such as Facebook, X and YouTube would face meaningful penalties, including fines and loss of access to the Canadian marketplace, for failing to protect Canadian users. This could be overseen by an independent digital safety commissioner with authority to enforce standards and ensure compliance. Such oversight, rooted firmly in Charter rights, would balance the need to protect Canadians with the safeguarding of civil liberties.

Additionally, the minister could fortify Canada's democratic resilience. Reintroducing an Elections Security Act, creating a foreign agent registry, enforcing strict transparency for online political ads and enhancing cybersecurity measures would effectively counteract covert influence campaigns and protect our electoral integrity.

Finally, the communications minister could champion the independence and reliability of Canadian news media through strong public support for local journalism and a significantly reformed and fully independent CBC. This has become even more critical with the increasing capabilities of generative artificial intelligence. Strengthening these institutions, as well as introducing a national AI literacy program, will be critical to maintaining diverse, reliable sources of information and giving Canadians the tools to discern truth from misinformation. Just as previous communications ministers nurtured Canada's broadcasting identity, a new minister could help Canadians navigate our complex digital landscape.

As Canada enters a federal election campaign, the stakes couldn't be higher. The integrity of our democracy depends on proactively securing our information system against those who wish us harm. Appointing a minister of communications and empowering them with an urgent mandate is a necessary step toward protecting Canadians — and Canada itself.

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